Ready for Revival / Revival under Josiah

Luke Johnston's selected teaching, writing or development sample; original bylines and citations retained.

Full teaching files

revival under josiah series message 1 *2 pages*

student revival under josiah series message 1 *1 pages*

revival under josiah series message 2 *3 pages*

student revival under josiah series message 2 *1 pages*

Teacher and student editions are components of this one portfolio entry.

I) The Religiosity of God's People

- Before revival comes, there must be a period of "dead" religiosity. If the people of God are not "dead" spiritually, producing no fruit, simply coasting along, then they need no "revival." (***Revive — bring back to life***)
- When Josiah shows up, his father and grandfather had been idolatrous, ungodly, awful men/kings of Judah. The state of God's people had never been so dire. God had pronounced judgment on his people and that he was going to judge them and bring them into captivity.

A) Their "religious" services were thriving, they still had:

1) The Temple, the High Priest and other Priests, Levites, Scribes, Officers and Porters, money and workers for God's House, Musicians, the Ark, and Prophets or other spiritual authorities— 2 Kgs. 22:3–20; 2 Chr. 34:8–18, 22–28; 35:2–6.

B) They did not have the Word of God — 2 Kings 22:8,13; 2 Chr. 34:14-15,21

1) They were doing all of their serving, sacrificing, giving of time, money, worshipping, etc.. all without the Word of God even present.
2) When we are busy "serving" but without the Word of God as the center, as the guide, as the thrust of our service; then we become "religious" and our worship is in vain and we end up and our children end up worshipping other "gods" — Matthew 15:8–9
3) This message is not just about churches or God's people as a whole, it is also about our individual lives! We can at times be busy in religious work, serving, sacrificing, etc.. but without the Word of God as our basis, we will fail!
4) That means our serving should involve personal reading, studying, obeying, and sharing of the Word of God. If it is not central to our lives as Christians, we are going about it the wrong way!
   (i) You may be thinking, "We have the Bible. I have the Bible. We talk about and teach the Bible. Etc… But we aren't talking about simply having it, but loving it, obeying it, and making it central to our Christian lives! "Finding the Law of the Lord" again! If we truly had, "found the law of the Lord" again as they did in Josiah's day, we would have radically changed lives, hearts, families, and entire counties, and countries turning to God as we will see happens in our story later.
5) I have discussed before how the "key of David" is a love for the Word of God; this is a theme throughout the Bible, Israel's history, and our lives! Without it, we are busy in vain. It is no coincidence that it was said of Josiah, 2 Kings 22:2 "And he did that which was right in the sight of the LORD, and walked in all the way of David his father, and turned not aside to the right hand or to the left."

C) Because they were busy in their traditions and religious services, without the Word of God as the driving force: they and their children had begun worshipping many false gods— 2 Chr. 34:3–7; 2 Kgs. 23:4–15; 2 Kgs. 23:19–20; 2 Kgs. 23:24

1) This is one of the most common patterns we see in the Bible. Those who claim to be God's people: discussing God, worshipping God, sacrificing to God, giving their lives for God, etc.. all outside of what God said he wants them to do in his word!
2) **KEY COMPARISON: Consider the relationship to Jesus day**:
   (i) They still had the temple, sacrifices, chief priests, scribes, elders, synagogues, tithes, fasts, prayers, etc. (Matt. 21:12–13; 23:1–7, 23; Jn. 2:13–16). They set aside the commandment of God in order to keep their traditions (Mark 7:8–9, 13; Matt. 15:1–6). Their real "gods" were the praise of men, outward appearance, self-righteousness, and money (Matt. 23:5–7, 25–28; Luke 16:14; Jn. 12:42–43).

II) The Rumblings of Revival

A) Jeremiah began ministering in Josiah's thirteenth year—five years before the Book was found in Josiah's eighteenth year— Jer. 1:2

B) Zephaniah ministered "in the days of Josiah", against worship of false gods— Zeph. 1:1–6

C) Josiah had been named centuries earlier in prophecy: 1 Kgs. 13:1–2

D) Josiah had already begun seeking the LORD in his eighth year and cleansing Judah and Jerusalem of idols in his twelfth year—six years before the Book was found in his eighteenth year— 2 Chr. 34:3, 8

1) God was already moving 300+ years before Josiah, prophesying of the revival under his reign, and preparing the environment and hearts of the people to receive it!
2) Again, this message is not just about churches or God's people as a whole, it is also about our individual lives!
3) In my life, before I had a real commitment to studying the Bible, loving and preaching the Bible; there were rumblings of God moving in my life. He took friends away, brought in new friends, set me up with the right discipler, had me in youth group, gave me people in my life to encourage me and tell me God had a plan for me, etc.. These were not the revival, but when that moment came, I was able to see the rumblings God had in my life to prepare me for that moment, that got me to that moment. The moment when I truly "found the word and tasted the honey, as David said in Psalm 119:103, "How sweet are thy words unto my taste! yea, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" When it became about more than knowing stories, and knowing information, but really forming a love for the Bible and a desire to share it with others!
4) **KEY COMPARISON: Consider again the relationship to Jesus day**:
   (i) Before the living Word, Jesus Christ, came, God gave prophecies of the Messiah and sent John the Baptist to prepare His way (Isa. 40:3; Mal. 3:1; Matt. 3:1–3; John 1:1, 14); likewise, before

the written Word was found in Josiah's day, Jeremiah and Zephaniah were already prophesying and preparing the people (Jer. 1:2; Zeph. 1:1–6; 2 Kgs. 22:8; 2 Chr. 34:14–15)

(ii) Before Jesus Christ ever came, God had given many prophecies concerning the coming Messiah (**Gen. 3:15; Isa. 7:14; 9:6–7; 53:1–12; Mic. 5:2; Zech. 9:9**). God also foretold that a messenger would come before Him to prepare His way (**Isa. 40:3; Mal. 3:1; 4:5–6**). Jn. the Baptist was that promised forerunner, crying in the wilderness and pointing men to Christ (**Matt. 3:1–3; 11:10; Luke 1:13–17, 76; Jn. 1:19–23**). In a similar pattern, Josiah's day had its own rumblings before the Book of the Law was found: Jeremiah and Zephaniah were already prophesying, preparing the way (**Jer. 1:2; Zeph. 1:1–6**). God was preparing the way for the appearing of His written Word in Josiah's day (**2 Kgs. 22:8; 2 Chr. 34:14–15**), as He was preparing the way for the living Word in Jesus' day (**Jn. 1:1, 14; Mark 1:1–3**).

III) The Return of The Word of God

A) In the midst of the religiosity and idolatry of Josiah's day, after God had prepared the people through rumblings of revival; the Word of God was found — 2 Chr. 34:14–15; 2 Kgs. 22:8

B) Josiah is the first to repent when confronted with the Word of God — 2 Kings 22:10-13; 2 Chr. 34:19–21, 27

1) Revival in our lives, our homes, our families, our churches, etc.. starts with the head.

(i) If you want a full revival in your personal life, it will come through your decisions alone. Nobody else is responsible for your actions, your life, your choices, and your life direction. Life is about your choices.

(ii) Anything you lead: business, family, home, etc.. revival will always depend on you as the leader. It starts with the head. This is a great responsibility, with great potential for good (and bad) — Jonah 3:6-7

C) When the Word of God is found and it is embraced with a humble, obedient heart, there will be a "reviving" (bringing to life) of things that were dead — Psalm 119:93,107,154; Jn. 5:24; Heb. 4:12; 1 Pet. 1:23

(i) The Word was read publicly, the idols were removed, idolatrous priests and high places were put away, occult practices, images, and other abominations were removed ,the priests and Levites were restored , the Passover was restored , the people were caused to serve the LORD for the rest of Josiah's days.

(ii) Revival had begun! Not some fake "manufactured" revival that we here too often about today. Not revival based on unbiblical practices, appealing to carnal desires, and manufacturing numbers to look like a big "Christian" movement.

(iii) REAL REVIVAL, based on the appearing of the Word of God again. Real revival that caused SIN TO CEASE, LIVES TO BE CHANGED, AND HEARTS TO BE COMMITED TO GOD AGAIN!

2) **KEY COMPARISON: Consider again the relationship to Jesus day**:

(i) When the living Word, Jesus Christ, showed up, He disrupted false worship, exposed the empty religious traditions of God's people, and caused a major stir in the whole region; and through the appearing of the living Word of God, many people have been "revived" and made alive through salvation in Jesus Christ.

IV) Next Week:

A) The Removal of the Idols

B) The Return of Passover

I) The _____ of God's People

A) Their "religious" services were thriving, they still had:

1) The Temple, the High Priest and other Priests, Levites, Scribes, Officers and Porters, money and workers for God's House, Musicians, the Ark, and Prophets or other spiritual authorities— 2 Kgs. 22:3–20; 2 Chr. 34:8–18, 22–28; 35:2–6.

B) They did not have the Word of God — 2 Kings 22:8,13; 2 Chr. 34:14-15,21

C) Because they were busy in their traditions and religious services, without the Word of God as the driving force: they and their children had begun worshipping many false gods— 2 Chr. 34:3–7; 2 Kgs. 23:4–15; 2 Kgs. 23:19–20; 2 Kgs. 23:24

1) This is one of the most common patterns we see in the Bible. Those who claim to be God's people: talking about God, worshipping God, sacrificing to God, giving their lives for God, etc. all outside of what God said he wants them to do, as stated in his Word!

2) **KEY COMPARISON: Consider the relationship to Jesus' day**:

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III) The _____ of The Word of God

A) Amid the religiosity and idolatry of Josiah's day, after God had prepared the people through rumblings of revival; the Word of God was found — 2 Chr. 34:3–7, 14–15; 2 Kgs. 22:8

B) Josiah is the first to repent when confronted with the Word of God — 2 Kings 22:10-13; 2 Chr. 34:19–21, 27

C) When the Word of God is found and it is embraced with a humble, obedient heart, there will be a "reviving" (bringing to life) of things that were dead — Psalm 119:93,107,154; Jn. 5:24; Heb. 4:12; 1 Pet. 1:23

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I) Rededication to the **Word**

A) Josiah makes a covenant to obey the Word — 2 Kgs. 23:3; 2 Chr. 34:31

B) The people stand to the covenant —2 Kgs. 23:3; 2 Chr. 34:32; Josh. 24:22–25

1) The Hebrew phrase used here for "make a covenant" is in Hebrew to "cut a covenant". It is a callback to the Hebrew practice of cutting an animal in half and walking through it: saying in affect, "If we don't keep this covenant/deal, let us be as this animal."

2) It was very serious business. Yet, we see all over the Bible man making covenants with God and to God. Getting together and saying we promise to obey the Word of God, we are taking it that seriously. If we don't, God let us be as this animal.

3) Genesis 15:10, 17–18— Abraham divides the animals, and the LORD symbolically passes between the pieces when He makes His covenant with Abraham.

4) No doubt, it is intense, and not to be taken lightly. The bible says, "When thou vowest a vow unto God, defer not to pay it; for he hath no pleasure in fools: pay that which thou hast vowed. Better is it that thou shouldest not vow, than that thou shouldest vow and not pay." Ecclesiastes 5:4–5

II) Removal of **Idolatry**

A) All of the idolatry, and everything associated with it, was finally removed — 2 Kgs. 23:4–20, 24; 2 Chr. 34:3–7, 33

1) Idols, images, groves, and pagan vessels; altars and high places; Baal worship; worship of the sun, moon, planets, and host of heaven; idolatrous priests; horses and chariots dedicated to the sun; Topheth and other pagan worship sites; houses connected with immoral idol worship; familiar spirits, wizards, teraphim, and other abominations — ALL removed!

2) This was no doubt painful, it was painful to the idolatrous people of Judah who loved their sin and comfortable "religiosity" — Jud. 18:24; Num. 11:4–6; 14:2–4; Mark 6:17–20

(i) In the book of Judges, we have a story of a guy named Micah from Israel, who built false idols and this was his response when they were taken away: "Ye have taken away my gods which I made, and the priest, and ye are gone away: and what have I more?" (Judg. 18:24)

(ii) Israel missed what they had left behind in Egypt and longed for the old food and lifestyle (Num. 11:4–6; 14:2–4).

(iii) Herod was unwilling to give up his sinful relationship when John the Baptist confronted him about it (Mark 6:17–20).

B) Josiah did not manage the idols or relocate the idols. He destroyed them — 2 Kgs. 23:4, 6, 8, 12, 14–15, 24

1) We are told he burned, stamped to powder, brake down, cut down, defiled, put away the idolatry

2) Similarly, we must do the same thing in our lives: we must completely rid our lives of whatever it is that is exalting itself against God in our lives — Rom. 13:14; Eph. 4:27; 1 Cor. 5:7

(i) What is taking most of our time? Our energy? Our thoughts? Our finances? Our concern? What are we paying attention to? If there are things that are keeping us from God and what he wants us to do, they MUST GO! Completely! As we will see next, any partial removal will not last and will only make matters worse!

(ii) Again, this is why "finding" the word of God again in our lives is so key. When we have truly "found" it again and it reigns in our lives: it is our desire, what we think/meditate on, what we live by, what we are concerned with, etc.. SO THAT WE CAN OBEY AND KNOW GOD.... then other "gods" cannot reign in our lives. Our life is already occupied with God and his Word!

C) Other kings had attempted reform before Josiah, but repeatedly left things behind

1) Asa, 1 Kgs. 15:14; Jehoshaphat, 1 Kgs. 22:43; Joash, 2 Kgs. 12:3; Amaziah, 2 Kgs. 14:4; Azariah, 2 Kgs. 15:4; Jotham, 2 Kgs. 15:35.

2) The only true "revival" of things that are dead and entrenched in sin and idolatry, comes through a "finding" of the word of God

(i) Many people try programs, self-help, counseling, psychology, accountability, conferences, seminars, new methods, new music, new leadership, new ministries, emotional experiences, resolutions, and behavior modification. BUT TRUE "revival", true lasting change comes through a renewed love for God through His word!

3) You want your life cleaned up? (Eph. 5:26; John 15:3) You want a thriving, exciting life; not deadness, purposeless, and just dragging through life? (Heb. 4:12; Ps. 119:25, 50; 1 Pet. 1:23) You want a changed life? To be transformed? To break old habits and become someone new? (Rom. 12:2; Col. 3:9–10; 2 Cor. 5:17)

(i) The Word of God is the answer: it is God's mind, how we know God in this world, it is the source of our salvation (Rom. 10:17; 1 Pet. 1:23), the truth we live by (John 17:17), what washes us (Eph. 5:26), changes and transforms us (Rom. 12:2; Jas. 1:21–25), renews us (Eph. 4:23), comforts us (Rom. 15:4), gives us guidance (Ps. 119:105), gives us wisdom and understanding (Ps. 119:98–100, 130), keeps us from sin (Ps. 119:11), corrects and instructs us (2 Tim. 3:16), gives us hope (Rom. 15:4), strengthens us (Ps. 119:28), helps us resist temptation (Matt. 4:4, 7, 10), builds us up (Acts 20:32), it is the source of the faith we are required to have in order to please God (Heb. 11:6; Rom. 10:17); it is the key to a successful Christian life and fruitfulness as servants of God (Psa. 1:1-3); and it is what thoroughly furnishes us "unto all good works" (2 Tim. 3:17).

(ii) Here are a few quotes on the Bible that pertain to all we have been discussing

III) Reinstating of the **Passover**

A) After false worship was removed, biblical worship was restored – 2 Kgs. 23:21–23; 2 Chr. 35:1–19

B) The Passover reminded them that they had been redeemed by blood — Exo. 12:13

1) The Passover lamb was pointing forward to Jesus Christ — 1 Cor. 5:7; Jn. 1:29; 1 Pet. 1:18-19

(i) When revival truly comes, people are brought back to the Lamb.

(ii) It is impossible to miss the connection here. They had moved beyond empty religiosity, rediscovered the Word of God, humbled themselves before it, rededicated themselves to obey it, removed the idols and false worship from the land, and restored their lives and worship according to what was written. And now, after all of that, they reinstitute something that had not been observed like this for hundreds of years: the Passover.

(iii) The Passover brought them back to the very foundation of their redemption: a spotless lamb was slain, the blood was applied, and judgment passed over because of the blood (Ex. 12:5–13). That makes this a tremendous picture of what happens in true revival today. The Word of God returns to its rightful place, sin and idols are confronted and removed, and then people are brought back to Jesus Christ, the Lamb of God

(iv) When the word of God is "found" again in our lives, we will see our family, friends, strangers, many people come to Christ for salvation! We will see them "revived", born again by the word of God!

IV) Conclusion

A) We are going to begin to close out, and so let's go ahead and have the musicians come forward

B) Consider: Where are you today?

1) **Do you feel like you are busy serving, going through the motions of Christian service but without any fruit to show for it?** YOU NEED TO CONSIDER REDEDICATING YOURSELF TO THE WORD OF GOD, SO YOU CAN DO THE WORK OF GOD EFFECTIVELY. CONSIDER PRAYING TO GOD AND ASKING HIM TO REIGNITE YOUR ZEAL FOR HIS WORD AND HIS WORK. WE CANNOT DO THE WORK WITHOUT HAVING FOUND THE WORD OF GOD AGAIN IN OUR LIVES.
   (i) TAKE THE DEDICATION SERIOUSLY, REMEMBER THE COVENANT THAT THEY TOOK IN JUDAH, IT WAS VERY SERIOUS BUSINESS, BUT GOD BLESSED THEM GREATLY, WITH REVIVAL, BECAUSE OF IT
2) **Maybe you are here and feel like your life is dead, you are dragging through life, and there seems to be trouble, sin, and issues everywhere you turn**. This was the state of Judah in Josiah's day. Their idols had taken over their lives, their homes, their worship, and even the house of God.
   (i) There may be some idols in your life that need removed. Maybe there are habits, relationships, desires, priorities, entertainment, possessions, or sins that have slowly taken a place that belongs to God. WHEN THE WORD OF GOD BEGINS TO REIGN, THE IDOLS HAVE TO GO. Do not manage them. Do not excuse them. Do not keep the "high places" around. Let the Word of God expose them, and determine today that whatever God says is wrong must go (2 Kgs. 23:24; Ps. 119:9, 11). If it is in a place in your life that the Word of God should be, it must go!
      (a) I'm sure many are thinking, "okay we get it, we need to read the Bible more." But that is missing the point. The point is, if you are giving other things in your life precedence over God and his Word, IT NEEDS TO CHANGE for "revival" to happen in your life!
   (ii) Maybe you have tried everything else to change. Programs, accountability, counseling, new routines, or simply trying harder. Those things may have their place, but lasting spiritual change comes as the Word of God gets into us and begins changing us from the inside out (Rom. 12:2; Jas. 1:21–25). Get back into the Book. Let God clean you, renew you, strengthen you, and transform you through His Word.
3) **Finally, maybe you are here and you have never truly been saved**. You need to receive Jesus Christ. We are told, "So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God. (Rom. 10:17). You have heard the Word of God today, Jesus died and bled for your sin (the lamb of God), and rose again, so that you could receive him and be "revived" and never die. You need to pray and receive Jesus Christ today!
   (i) For believers, once we see revival in our lives, through the word of God, we will see a reinstitution of the Passover: people will start being born again around us! We must return to the word of God, we must find it, so that this can happen!

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